

Figure 4: The Ubuntu "Me Menu"

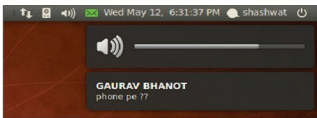


Figure 5: System notification

didn't happen on the Acer 5740G laptop, though.

Ubuntu has rejuvenated the Software Centre, which can now install multiple applications in one go—it sports a new look (Figure 6), and allows you to manage repositories through a Software Sources menu option. While the interface is clean and easy to use, especially for new users, Software Centre hangs now and then, and is not as responsive as the good old Synaptic Package Manager.

Ubuntu has replaced the GIMP with F-Spot, a move that has been criticised by the Ubuntu community. The GIMP is a powerful raster image editor with, till date, no equal on Linux. Ubuntu has included a video editor instead! I still don't understand that: how many of us need a video editor in the default install? PTTiVi isn't a great solution for video editing either. Is Ubuntu trying to imitate Windows' default software collection?

Lucid also comes with the latest Firefox browser, which provides stunning browsing speed, and looks great with the new Personas theme engine.

Lucid includes a Disk Manager (Figure 7) developed by Red Hat; this nifty tool is a life-saver for people who want to check their hard disk status, and the inclusion is surely a great idea. The tool works as a wrapper for SMART (Self Monitoring and Reporting Tool), and displays information about your hard disk in a streamlined manner.

Hardware support

While Lucid does have much better hardware support than earlier versions, there are a few areas that need work. Lucid worked flawlessly with the desktop, and Acer and Dell Inspiron laptops, but there was no sound on the Dell Studio laptop, nor did Bluetooth work (which worked fine on the other laptops). The only work-around for the sound problem was to compile the latest ALSA package and install it. Though Lucid failed to get composing working on the Acer 5740G, the blame in this



Figure 6: Ubuntu Software Centre home screen

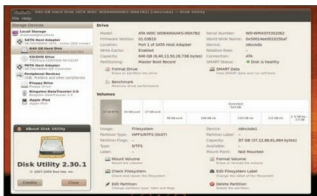


Figure 7: Disk utility

case goes to AMD—drivers were not ready in time for the newly released Evergreen series of cards that came with the new laptop.

Printer support is top-notch as usual, and what's eye-catching is the iPod support. Now you don't have to use some third-party iPod manager software to sync songs; Rhythmbox does the job well. But still, lack of a feature-rich stand-alone iPod manager is becoming a sore point for iPod users.

Summing up

Ubuntu 10.04 has no doubt undergone immense work to provide a near-perfect desktop experience, even though the sound and Bluetooth problems on the Studio laptop were a let-down. And though Lucid proudly wears the LTS badge, it still looks an experimental release to me. The inclusion of buggy or experimental software like Plymouth, Gwibber and the Software Centre are the downside of this release.

Still, I feel Ubuntu has done it again; for me, 10.04 is the next best release after the Feisty Fawn (7.04). To those who are still waiting to give Linux a try, this is the version to start with!

After all those years spent with other distros, I think I am going the Ubuntu way again with Lucid Lynx. I am having fun on the Lynx; are you ready for it? 

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